The true scale of the challenge to Ulbricht became clear during January when a cabal of thirteen Politburo members and candidates composed a carefully phrased letter to Brezhnev putting down a marker against the First Secretary.28 Ulbricht, the letter stated, had not been in a position since the middle of 1970 to properly address reality. Furthermore, they castigated him for not adhering to Politburo and Central Committee decisions, but rather of repeatedly questioning them. Moreover, they berated him for advocating his own line vis-à-vis the Federal Republic in contrast to the SED's agreed-upon procedure with Moscow. In chronicling Ulbricht's decline, they charged that as he deviated from the joint resolutions of the brother parties of the Warsaw Pact, it was no longer guaranteed that the forthcoming eighth Party Congress could come to a unified opinion on international issues. As if that wasn't bad enough, the letter decried the fact that Ulbricht increasingly considered himself infallible – on a par with Marx, Engels and Lenin. The conclusion: Ulbricht should be disempowered with Moscow's blessing, but the overthrow must be presented as a 'normal transition' from an older man to a younger man. For half a dozen Politburo members that refused to sign the letter (including Albert Norden and Alfred Neumann), there was sadness at the soiling of Ulbricht's person. And as the First Secretary's edifice of authority began to crumble, it took Brezhnev another three months of procrastinating before acting.